

So you're thinking about veterinary medicine

The short version — written for you, not about you.

Everything that matters, none of the bits written for your parents.

If you've wanted this since you were about nine, you're in good company — and that's worth saying up front, because the instinct is a good one.

We scored twenty-seven careers on how exposed they are to AI. Small animal practice came out at **2.7 out of 10**. Large animal and emergency work: **2.5**.

Those are among the lowest scores we found anywhere. Entry-level software development is 8.1.

So the AI question is settled. The things worth thinking hard about are different, and this document is mostly about those.

The 60-second version

- Veterinary medicine is one of the most protected careers we measured. All four protections working at once.
 - The reason is unusual: **your patient can't tell you anything**.
 - The real issues are the debt and the emotional side — both serious, both manageable if you know about them.
 - Average debt for vets who have it: \$212,499, and it's climbing again.
 - And there's a route most people never consider properly.
-

Why it's so protected — and the reason is interesting

Most protected careers are protected by something obvious: a licence, physical presence, legal liability. Veterinary has all of those.

But it also has something almost nothing else does.

Human medicine starts with the patient telling you what's wrong. Where it hurts, when it started, what makes it worse. That description is the richest input in clinical reasoning — and it's text, which is exactly what AI handles best.

Your patient gives you none of that.

No complaint. No timeline. An animal that may be actively hiding pain by instinct. An owner's second-hand and often wrong account. And whatever you can work out by touching an animal that doesn't want to be touched.

Then multiply by species — a dog, a horse and a rabbit in one morning, with three completely different physiologies and drug tolerances.

Diagnostic AI works well when you feed it structured findings. Veterinary work is mostly about generating those findings from a non-verbal, uncooperative, physically present patient. No system does that.

The transferable idea: when you look at any career, ask where its information comes from. If it arrives as text or data, it's exposed. If a human has to generate it from the physical world first, it's protected.

The scores

TRACK	SCORE
Emergency & critical care	2.4
Large animal / mixed practice	2.5
Veterinary specialist / surgery	2.5
Small animal general practice	2.7
Veterinary nurse / technician	3.0
Lab / diagnostic roles	5.4

Note the last row. Move the work away from the animal and behind a microscope, and the exposure roughly doubles. Same pattern as every career we scored.

What AI is actually doing

Mostly the paperwork. Records, history notes, billing, reminders, dose lookup, first-pass X-ray reads.

Veterinary practices are drowning in admin, so this is one of the more straightforwardly good developments in the whole index. It gives time back to the animals.

What it can't touch: examining an animal that resists it, surgery, handling a frightened or aggressive patient, or telling someone their dog is dying.

The money, honestly

This is the part that deserves real attention.

The AVMA — the profession's own body — tracks this every year, and the picture has moved.

It got better. The debt-to-income ratio for new graduates fell from 1.70 in 2021 to 1.44 in 2022, and sat at **1.4 for 2024 graduates**. That's close to what's considered manageable.

Then it started getting worse again. Average debt across all 2025 graduates — including those with none — hit \$174,484, up from \$153,972 in 2022. For those who do have debt, the average is \$212,499.

And the average hides a lot: more than a quarter of one recent graduating cohort had debt at **twice** their starting salary or more.

Median vet pay is around **\$125,510**, with real variation — Massachusetts, California and Hawaii average above \$155,000, rural states \$20,000–\$30,000 lower.

Two things almost nobody tells applicants

Relief work. Relief vets do per-diem shifts across different practices instead of working full-time at one. Rates run \$55–\$125 an hour, day rates \$600–\$1,000. **Four days a week can be \$120,000–\$160,000.** It's a genuine strategy for clearing debt faster and very few people applying to vet school know it exists.

And you don't need thousands of unpaid hours to get in. The AVMA has said explicitly that **applicants don't need enormous quantities of unpaid veterinary experience to be admitted.** That guidance exists because the expectation was pushing people into years of unpaid work before an already expensive degree.

Get *meaningful* experience. Don't fund years of it you didn't need.

The part we'd rather tell you now than at 26

The emotional side of this job is real, unusual, and the profession talks about it openly — which is to its credit.

Three things make it distinctive:

Euthanasia is routine. Few careers involve ending life regularly. It doesn't become trivial, and people who do it well don't pretend otherwise.

You'll often know exactly what would help an animal and not be able to do it, because the owner can't afford it. There's no real equivalent in human medicine, and vets consistently name it among the hardest parts of the job.

And client conflict, sometimes at moments of grief or financial stress.

Here's the important bit: the profession has built genuine support around this — the AVMA and equivalent bodies run wellbeing programmes, peer networks and confidential assistance, and vet schools now build it into training rather than leaving you to discover it.

None of that is a reason not to do this. It's a reason to go in knowing, to take the support seriously rather than assuming you should cope alone, and to choose where you work as carefully as what you do.

Does this actually sound like you?

The most common misapprehension about this career, and worth being honest about:

A lot of people choose veterinary medicine because they prefer animals to people. Much of the job is managing people. Owners who are frightened, grieving, angry about a bill, or convinced they know what's wrong. If dealing with humans is the part you're hoping to avoid, that's worth knowing now.

It suits people who:

- Are interested in animals **and** comfortable with people
- Are **physically confident** with animals, including big and frightened ones
- Can hold **clinical, financial and emotional pressure** in the same ten-minute consultation
- Are **practical problem-solvers** rather than pure academics
- Can **carry difficult things** without being flattened by them

Harder if you struggle with conflict — especially about money — find grief hard to be around repeatedly, or need predictable hours.

The route nobody considers properly

Veterinary nursing.

- **Two to three years** instead of six or seven
- Hands-on animal care every single day
- A fraction of the debt
- Scores **3.0** — basically the same protection

Lower pay and less autonomy, genuinely. But if what pulls you is **being with animals and caring for them** rather than diagnosis, surgery and running a practice — **this is often the job people are actually picturing when they say they want to be a vet.**

Worth a serious look rather than a dismissal.

What actually matters when picking a school

- **Total cost.** Compare it properly across schools — the difference lasts decades and dwarfs almost everything else.
 - **How many species and settings** do you actually see? Small animal only, or large animal and emergency too?
 - **Licensure exam pass rate**
 - **How wellbeing support is built into the course** — not whether it exists, but whether it's part of training
-

Two things worth doing

Spend real time in a practice — including the boring parts, the difficult conversations, and ideally an emergency shift. Not a day of watching puppies. The actual job.

Then find a vet three to five years qualified and ask directly about their loan payments and whether they'd pick the same school again. It's an awkward question and the answer is worth a lot.

One last thing

If you've wanted this for years, don't let any of the above talk you out of it. It's a genuinely protected career, the work is described by the people doing it in terms much closer to vocation than job, and the instinct that got you here is a good one.

Just go in with the numbers and the difficulties in front of you — alongside the ambition, not instead of it.

If you want to go further — three things worth twenty minutes

- **[Veterinarians — Occupational Outlook Handbook](#)** — government data on pay and growth. Read the **Veterinary Technologists and Technicians** page right after it.
 - **[AVMA reports and statistics](#)** — the profession's own annual data on debt and starting salaries. Where every money figure above comes from.
 - **[VIN Student Debt Center](#)** — practical, written by people inside the profession, and not selling you a course.
-

There's a longer version behind this — full scores by track, how they were worked out, the financial picture in detail, what to ask a school, and where we might be wrong. Your parents have it.